

Gram Propst

CP World Literature and Composition

Ms. Otteman

September 29th, 2025

Isolation, Segregation and Control: The 1950's Nuclear Family

A white picturesque home sits on a well-manicured green lawn; a sidewalk stretches out in front of the building leading to the rest of the identical neighboring houses. Inside the home, a father has just come back from his well-paid office job, greeting his loving wife as she works to make supper for him and the kids. The nuclear family is an idealized family structure for middle class families in post-World War 2 America that was spread through idealized portrayals in media like this. The nuclear family was highly based on the cultural values in the era of strict gender roles and consumer culture. These cultural values informed the expectations of the nuclear family, enforcing the adherence to the strict societal norms of the era, doing irreparable harm to the families. The idea of a nuclear family would be the basis of the general understanding of a family structure in the west for generations to come. The culture of isolation, segregation and control of 1950s nuclear family can be represented by three symbols, the identical suburban neighborhoods, the television in each of those homes and the workwear of the men and women watching those televisions.

Suburbs are a harsh style of housing development that represented the expected identity of the nuclear family, crushing any hope for individuality and difference. The

suburbs became a hallmark of the nuclear family, representing the sameness and lack of community encouraged by the culture and the government of the time (Peters). Individuality is a core facet of human experience, one that is robbed by the complete identity of the suburbs. The French anthropologist Marc Augé coined the term “non-place” as place that lacks any identity, history or sense of belonging; simply acting as a functional or transitional location (Argüelles). The suburban homes are the epitome of the non-place, acting as a purely functional location, lacking any individuality, history or identity. These non-places are damaging to the families that reside in them as they rob them of culture, historical connection and any sense of self-identity within their home. Having a home that represents one’s culture and identity is important to not feeling isolated and maintaining a sense of self-identity apart from the cultural norm that is enforced on every part of the nuclear family. The isolation and sameness of the suburbs is representative of the same feelings in classic nuclear family structure. The suburbs further represent the isolation of the nuclear family through the lack of a diverse community structure. Having a diverse community and regular interactions with new people is incredibly important to human development and maintenance of the psyche; it encourages neuroplasticity, a sense of belonging and general emotional wellbeing. Suburbs act as a symbol for the nuclear family’s lack of community or interaction as they rob them of any chance of community building for pure functionality and convenience. The suburbs were heavily based on the car culture of the 1950’s. by making every part of the infrastructure built around the automobile it stripped these areas of any places people could interact other than work or home (Carolyn). This leaves the nuclear family trapped in their identical home on their identical street leaving there only social interactions to friendly greetings with neighbors and casual conversations with cashiers.

Television acts as a symbol and representation for 2 core values and goals of the culture of the 1950s nuclear family, separation from members of society deemed undesirable and the general disregard for the children of the family's happiness and wellbeing. Television, which had become a household staple in homes across America by 1955, acted as a cultural educator for families and children (Lehrman Institute). The television often portrayed a idealized nuclear family that was supposedly representative of the modern American family. This representation helped reinforce the cultural standards that a white, 4-person family in the suburbs was the ideal American family and that all others were lesser. This portrayal would make more middle-class families move to the suburbs and isolate others that didn't fit into the cultural ideal. It also reinforced the idea of suburbs as a haven from the minorities deemed to be a threat to suburban American life. This was done by portraying these groups as dangerous or undesirable in portrayals of the nuclear family. This reflects the emphasis on separation from minorities or members of society that did not fit the cultural norm in the nuclear family. The television acted as a symbol of the segregation encouraged by the culture of the nuclear family, but it also acts as symbol of the lack of activities or entertainment for the children of the suburban nuclear family. The culture of the nuclear family is not designed for the happiness and well-being of the children, especially when it comes to entertainment or social interaction. When it comes to entertainment children have practically nothing other than the television. The father of the family isn't expected to help with child raising, or even play with them from time to time and the mother is expected to do all the housework and any other domestic duties, leaving little time for child care. Even the suburbs are laid out in a way that limits any chance of getting anywhere without a car. This leaves the children with little options for entertainment other than the TV. The

Tv symbolizes this issue as it is the decided upon solution to this lack of actual interaction for most nuclear families.

Gender roles are one of the main cultural beliefs that held the nuclear family together and can be symbolically represented by the culturally expected work wear of the adults in the family. The adults in the nuclear family are heavily divided in their role and the cultural norms expected of them, but they both share one thing; they are completely and utterly trapped in their role and cannot vary for threat of societal shunning. This lack of freedom past the socially assigned gender roles is a core value of the culture of the nuclear family. The women's roles can be symbolized by the apron, as the mother of the family is expected to keep up with all of the domestic chores and child raising while also making sure that she meets the unattainably high beauty standards for women at the time. The apron acted as a necessity for these conflicting ideas to mix, absorbing the utter messiness and chaos of raising a family while letting the women still keep up her expected appearance. This constant struggle of trying to achieve both conflicting goals made any attempt at pursuing other hopes and dreams utterly impossible; Trapping women through social stigma and the burdening of responsibilities represented by the apron. The nuclear family's cultural belief of the roles of men was that they should be the strong leaders of the family, maintaining complete control and adherence to the social norm. this cultural belief can be represented by the suit and tie that was the normal work wear of most office working men at the time. The suit represented authority and adherence to the social norm, both qualities that were culturally expected of the father of the house. In the culture of the 1950s the suit acted as a sign of power, distinguishing the middle- and upper-class men from the working and lower class. This demonstration of power was expected of men in the work place and at home, where they were expected to be in charge and commanding the family. The suit symbolically represented the

power and control expected of men by the culture of the nuclear family. Power and control that was based in fear of breaking the norms of the culture of the nuclear family, also represented by the suit. As the suit was the main professional attire of the era, variation from this norm would result in social punishment. This same attitude was taken for the nuclear family; any variation from the cultural norms of the nuclear family would be thought of as a failing of the father, further drawing symbolism between the suit and tie and the cultural expectations and values of the father in the nuclear family.

The culture of the 1950s nuclear family is one of isolation, separation and control. Isolated families in seemingly infinite identical neighborhoods, television promoting fear mongering and separation, and the adults of the home trapped in their own prisons of the gender roles they were assigned at birth. This flawed 1950s culture has so fundamentally informed our societal understanding of the ideal family structure that it is believed to be the only family structure that is viewed as normal or not a failure. But it is not. The standard American family is not one represented by the isolation of the suburbs or the fear mongering of the television or gender roles enforced by clothing; It is one represented by love, respect and community.